to Harry Di, as she is fondly know in the dressing room.

It's been a long, arduous road for women cricketers to relish this euphoria. Harmanpreet has been on it too, which is why she wanted her seniors, Jhulan Goswami and Anjum Chopra, to join in the celebrations and lift the trophy. "Our cricket is alive because of players like them. They played when things were not that great. Their love for the game meant they didn't give up," she notes. Kaur has played in many empty stadiums and seen many a fine talent quit cricket because families stopped supporting and insisted on "thinking about the family" (read: get married and have kids). It didn't help that the pay wasn't great either and matches—both domestic and international—fewer. Media spotlight? A rarity.

IN A LEAGUE OF HER OWN

It explains why Kaur didn't know there was a women's team let alone any female cricketers when she took to the field, accompanying her brother to matches their father would play with friends. They'd stand behind the wicket-keeper and wait for the ball to come to them. When it wouldn't and their roles never extended beyond fielding, the kids decided to form their own team. She was the only girl on it but she was a natural. Other girls came but only when they were a player short and didn't last long. "We were very competitive and aggressive," she says. Kaur's idol then? Virendra Sehwag. Like him she whipped the ball off boundary lines. "We used to play four to five over matches and there was no time to settle. You hit from ball one," she recalls. Former cricketer Noopur, now her manager and friend, remembers her as the girl who struck sixes with ease. Nobody was surprised that after two years on the domestic circuit playing for Punjab, Kaur was wearing the coveted blue jersey.

Kaur was there when she saw things take a leap after the team reached the finals of the ODI World Cup in 2017. For starters, the Board of Cricket for Control in India introduced central contracts for women players. The beginning of Women's Premier League further brought more eyeballs and talent into the game (Kaur has won the WPL twice with Mumbai Indians). She acknowledges the ef-



AFP

Kaur's aggressive, clean-swinging, and power-packed batting action (Right); Lifting the ICC Women's Cricket World Cup in 2025 (Opposite page)